Responsible Administrator: Provost
Responsible Office: Dir Assessment and Accreditation
Effective Date: Fall 2024
Approved by: Academic Affairs Council
Date of Revision: 08/14/2024

Substantive Change Reporting Requirements Policy

Policy Statement

A substantive change as defined by the Southern Association of Colleges and Schools Commission on Colleges (SACSCOC) is "a significant modification or expansion in the nature and scope of an accredited institution" (SACSCOC Substantive Change Policy and Procedures). Accredited institutions with SACSCOC are required to notify SACSCOC of substantive changes, and when required, obtain approval before initiating such changes. If an institution is non-compliant with the SACSCOC Substantive Change Policy and Procedures, its accreditation may be in jeopardy. Non-compliance subjects the institution to monitoring, sanction, or removal from membership. Failure to secure approval, if required, of a substantive change involving programs or locations that qualify for title IV federal funding may place the institution in jeopardy with the U.S. Department of Education, including reimbursement of funds received related to an unreported substantive change.

Southeastern Louisiana University is committed to ensuring that all substantive changes are reported to SACSCOC in accordance with SACSCOC policy.

Purpose of Policy

The purpose of Southeastern's substantive change policy and procedure is to ensure all substantive changes are reported to the University's accreditation body, SACSCOC, as required by the SACSCOC Substantive Change Policy and Procedures document.

Applicability

This policy applies to all changes at the University that are substantive changes as defined by the SACSCOC Substantive Change Policy and Procedures document.

As defined by the SACSCOC Substantive Change Policy and Procedures document, substantive change is a "significant modification or expansion of the nature and scope of an accredited institution." Substantive changes include, but are not limited to the following:

- Adding a program that is a significant departure from the existing programs, or method of delivery, from those offered when the institution was last evaluated.
- Adding an additional method of delivery to a currently offered program.
- Substantially increase or decreasing the number of clock hours or credit hours awarded or competencies demonstrated, or an increase in the level of credential awarded, for successful completion of one or more programs.
- Adding programs with completion pathways that recognize and accommodate a student's prior or existing knowledge or competency.
- Awarding dual or joint academic awards.
- Adding a new off-campus instructional site/additional location including a branch campus.
- Closing an institution, a program, a method of delivery, an off-campus instructional site, or a program at an off-campus instructional site.

Policy Procedure

Procedures for Notification

Vice presidents, deans, and department heads should be aware of the Substantive Change Reporting Requirements and must work with the SACSCOC Accreditation Liaison to provide all information necessary to report a substantive change to SACSCOC. The SACSCOC Accreditation Liaison will coordinate any additional paperwork, such as a prospectus, and internal and external approval.

It is the responsibility of the head of the department in which an academic program resides to ensure that SACSCOC requirements of notification or approval have been met prior to implementing any substantive change concerning an academic program in his/her department. For substantive changes requiring notification only, the SACSCOC Accreditation Liaison prepares the letter of notification after having received the requisite approved internal documentation regarding the change.

For substantive changes requiring SACSCOC approval prior to implementation, the requisite SACSCOC documentation is typically prepared by the department head and is then submitted for review and consideration for approval through the supervisory line to the SACSCOC Accreditation Liaison and then to the Provost (Director/Department Head >Dean > SACSCOC Accreditation Liaison >Provost). The SACSCOC Accreditation Liaison is available to work with the Dean and Department Head during the preparation of the documentation.

Some substantive changes are more global to the university environment. For any of these substantive changes, the initiation and preparation of the documentation as well as the requisite internal approval process will be determined on a case-by-case basis in accordance with relevant University of Louisiana System and Board of Regents policies or rules.

Only the President or the SACSCOC Accreditation Liaison may submit to SACSCOC substantive change notifications and requests for substantive change approvals.

The SACSCOC Accreditation Liaison will be responsible for the following:

1. Ensuring that compliance with Substantive Change requirements is incorporated into the planning and evaluation process of the institution.
2. Serving as a standing member of the Curriculum Committee to provide guidance each academic year to members of the Committee to define Substantive Changes and describe the processes.
3. Preparing Substantive Change notification letters and documentation in accordance with the substantive change policies of SACSCOC.
4. Submitting Substantive Change documentation to SACSCOC.
5. Ensuring all timelines (provided by SACSCOC Substantive Change policy) are followed and Substantive Change notifications and/or prospectuses for approval are submitted in a timely manner to SACSCOC.
6. Staying informed of SACSCOC revisions to Substantive Change policies and procedures.
7. Attending training provided by SACSCOC on Substantive Change.
8. Maintaining a database for submitted Substantive Changes that have been approved by SACSCOC.
9. Serving as the contact person between SACSCOC staff and the institution on all matters regarding Substantive Change.

The current university SACSCOC Accreditation Liaison is:

Dr. Alexandra Anderson
Director of Assessment and Accreditation and SACSCOC Accreditation Liaison
alexandra.anderson-2@selu.edu

Submission Deadlines

1. Submission Deadlines per SACSCOC Substantive Change Policy and Procedures for a substantive change requiring approval by the Executive Council of the Board of Trustees (which meets year round), the submission deadlines are:
    a) January 1 for changes to be implemented July 1 through December 31 of the same calendar year, and
    b) July 1 for changes to be implemented January 1 through June 30 of the subsequent calendar year.
2. For a Substantive Change requiring notification only, it can be submitted any time before implementation.

[End of Policy]